

CUT • ROOT • ESTABLISH

The fig cutting fieldbook

A practical reference for turning dormant wood into a manageable young plant—not just a photograph of an opening bud.



FIRST	THEN	ONLY AFTER
Identify wood and orientation.	Document actual roots.	Pot on and adjust exposure.

Inside: cut maps, method comparisons, container sections, measured layouts, development plates, case decisions, and usable batch records.

24 pages. Original schematic illustrations. Worked quantities and batch outcomes are labeled examples, not prescriptions or expected success rates.

DECISION DESK

Choose the route before the date

What you actually have	Choose	Arrange first
Leafless mature wood in dormancy	Hardwood container route, pages 4–10	Labeled material, drainage, protected space.
One-year dormant stems + suitable nursery bed	Outdoor row, page 6	Local timing and a marked, maintained bed.
Leafy soft growth	A dedicated softwood method	Moisture-loss control; not a dormant-stem recipe.
Flexible low attached branch	Layering, page 21	Secure rooting zone; keep the parent connection.
Rooted sucker	A rooted-material method	Confirm roots and prepare aftercare.

Three questions that decide the next action

- 1. Is the material dormant, actively leafy, or already rooted?
- 2. Which complete protocol describes that material?
- 3. Where will the plant go after this stage?

A calendar date without a location and plant stage is incomplete information. Do not mix a Georgia nursery-row date with a protected indoor softwood setup.

INTAKE SHEET

Keep the donor identity attached

Field	Example record	Why it matters
Donor identity	Chicago Hardy — original nursery label retained	Names should survive separation and potting.
Source	My labeled parent tree; collection date recorded	A leaf photograph alone does not establish cultivar.
Stem state	Dormant, firm wood; soft tip excluded	Material must match the chosen route.
Visible condition	No observed soft or expanding damaged area	This is an observation, not a disease-free certificate.
Individual IDs	CH-01 through CH-12	Tray position is not a permanent identity.

A label that moves with the plant

CH-04 | donor: Chicago Hardy | cut: _____ | method: UF/IFAS container

Write the full donor provenance in the notebook. Mark the basal end before pieces are mixed.

Intake decision	Record before proceeding
Identity uncertain	Use “unknown edible fig”; do not invent a cultivar.
Material visibly deteriorating	Keep it out of the propagation batch pending assessment.
No suitable aftercare space	Reduce the batch before taking more wood.

ANATOMY PLATE

The node, the bud, the two ends

READ THE STEM BEFORE CUTTING

6 in / 15.2 cm

NODE + BUD

Retain the structure; do not cut through the bud.

TOP

Upper end stays upward.
Angled cut marks orientation.

BASAL END

Cut just below a node. This end enters the medium.

UF/IFAS six-inch example; basal wood is two years old. Node spacing is schematic.

Structure	Your check
Node and bud	Locate before the final cut; avoid slicing through the bud.
Basal end	The original lower end enters the rooting medium.
Upper end	Keep upward; use a consistent cut-shape cue plus the label.

The ruler describes the UF/IFAS example, not an exact position for every node. Do not substitute drawing proportions for the actual stem.

PROTOCOL COMPARISON

Keep each recipe together

Source / setting	Material	Placement
UF/IFAS container example	About 6 in; less than 1 in diameter; two-year wood at the base	Porous moist medium; at least half buried; base below a node.
Rutgers hardwood approach	About 9 in; pencil to no more than 3/4 in thick; straight woody growth	Base buried, top exposed; well-drained medium or protected nursery.
UGA C945 home nursery	8–10 in one-year wood; discard soft tips	Only upper bud exposed; about 10 in apart in the nursery row.

Do not average protocols

A six-inch container cutting is not “too short” merely because a nursery method uses ten inches. Record which protocol you followed and the actual measurements.

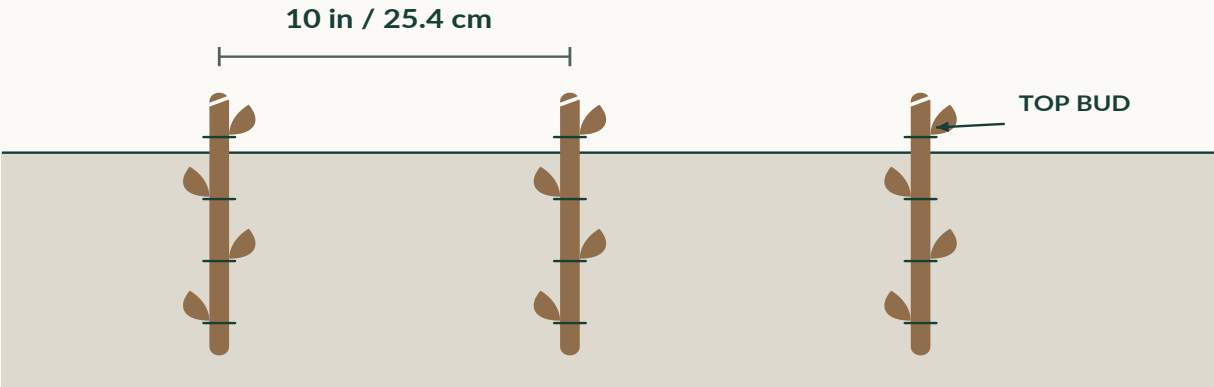
Measurement check	Worked conversion
6 inches	$6 \times 2.54 = 15.24$ cm
8–10 inches	20.32–25.40 cm
9 inches	22.86 cm

Choose the route that fits the material and location. The conversions translate units; they do not resolve differences in methods.

MEASURED ALTERNATIVE

A nursery row is a propagation bed

OUTDOOR NURSERY ROW — NOT ORCHARD SPACING



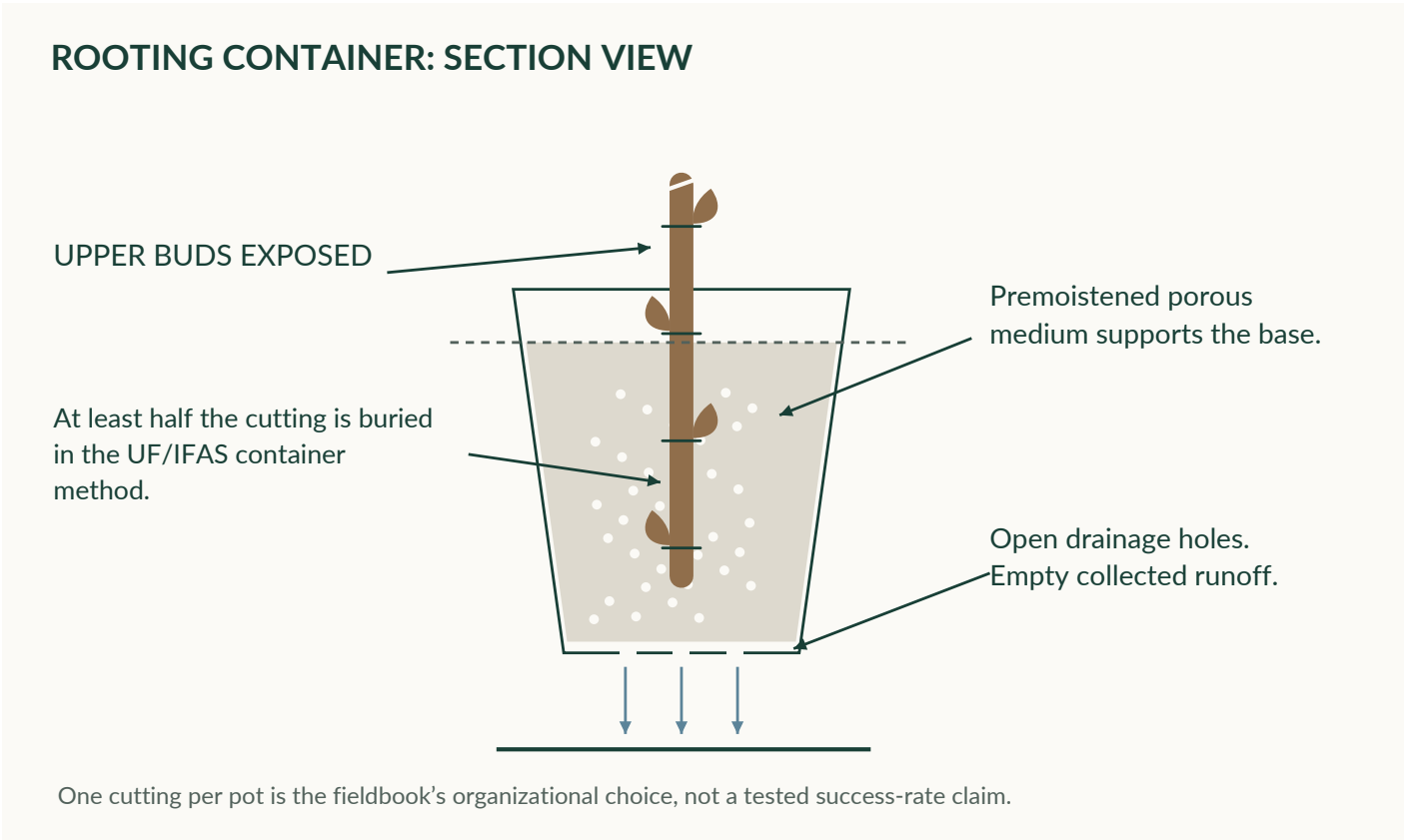
UGA C945 home-garden method: 8–10-inch one-year stems, only the top bud exposed. Georgia seasonal guidance is not a national planting date.

Plan item	What to record
Location and timing	UGA specifies late February for its Georgia home-garden method. Use locally suitable conditions elsewhere.
Bed identity	Mark the row so dormant stems are not mistaken for debris.
Maintenance	Keep the bed appropriately watered and accessible through establishment.
Destination	Rooting-row spacing is not spacing for mature fig trees.

This page follows C945 specifically. Other propagation publications use different nursery spacing; do not merge their dimensions into this plan.

CONTAINER SECTION

Build the root-zone setup



Before inserting	Confirm
Medium	Clean porous rooting material, premoistened and drained.
Container	Open holes, stable base, accessible drainage.
Cutting	Correct polarity; intended buried length fits without forcing.

The article's main container example follows UF/IFAS. One cutting per pot is used to simplify identity and later handling.

WORK SURFACE CHECKLIST

The sticking sequence

Step	Physical action	Checkpoint
01 Prepare	Label pots; moisten and drain medium before cutting.	The receiving setup is ready.
02 Identify	Find nodes; mark the basal and upper ends.	The correct end is still obvious.
03 Cut	Make the selected protocol's cuts with a clean sharp tool.	No bud is cut through.
04 Insert	Make an opening, insert the base, bring medium into contact.	The stem is supported, not forced.
05 Drain	Allow excess water to escape and empty retained runoff.	No hidden water reservoir.
06 Record	Photograph the label and setup.	Date, method and identity are recoverable.

Set the batch size before the first cut

Lay out the labels, pots, medium, and aftercare positions first. An extra handful of unlabeled cuttings is not a useful improvement to a traceable small batch.

Wear gloves when handling fig sap. A rooting product is optional according to the chosen protocol; use its label, not a homemade concentration.

BENCH PLANNER

Measure the space you will maintain

A MEASURED BENCH EXAMPLE

40 cm

30 cm

09

10

11

12

05

06

07

08

01

02

03

04

8 × 8 cm pots

10 cm centers

2 cm rim gaps

1 cm edge clearance

12 containers fit geometrically. Re-space as leaves grow; this is not a recommended fig canopy spacing.

Arithmetic	Result
4 columns × 3 rows	12 containers
10 cm centers – 8 cm pot width	2 cm between adjacent rims
$(40 - 3 \times 10 - 8) \div 2$	1 cm edge clearance at either end
12 pots × assumed 0.5 L medium each	6 L medium for this example

Replace dimensions and fill volume with measurements of your own pots. Re-space as foliage develops; geometric capacity is not aftercare capacity.

Original geometric example • Not a plant-spacing prescription

09 / 24

SETUP COMPARISON

Manage the air and medium separately

PROTECTED DOES NOT MEAN WATERLOGGED



BRIGHT, PROTECTED POSITION

Check the real exposure and leave room for new growth. Keep drainage accessible.

COVER AND WATER ARE DIFFERENT CONTROLS

A cover changes the air around the shoot. It does not turn retained runoff into a suitable rooting medium.

Increase ventilation gradually as the rooted plant adjusts. No universal cover-removal date.

Observation	Next check
Cover drips; pot remains heavy	Inspect medium and drainage before watering.
New leaves reach the cover	Check clearance and the next ventilation step.
A direct beam now reaches the setup	Reassess the actual position; do not copy mature-tree sun exposure.
Foliage wilts after a change	Compare exposure with medium condition, not the clock alone.

DEVELOPMENT ATLAS

The three-stage observation plate

THREE OBSERVATIONS, NOT ONE DEADLINE

BUD OPENS



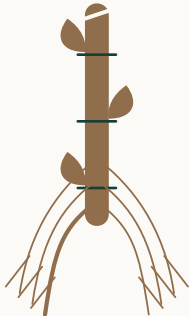
Shoot growth is visible. Root development is still a separate question.

CALLUS



Basal tissue change is not the same as a branching root system.

ROOTS



Record actual roots and later establishment, not only leaf count.

Schematic comparisons. Development rates vary; the drawings do not set a required root count.

Observation recorded	What it does not establish
Bud opening	A developed root system.
Basal callus	A root count or a ready-to-transplant plant.
Roots observed	Tolerance of every outdoor condition.

A rooted plant still has a transition ahead. Do not collapse bud growth, roots, and establishment into one “success” checkbox.

INSPECTION MAP

Observe roots with minimum disturbance

LOOK WITHOUT REPEATEDLY UPROOTING



CONTAINER EDGE
Record visible roots where the container permits a view.

DRAINAGE OPENING
Look; do not pull roots out through the holes.

Not visible is not the same as absent. Log “not observed without disturbance” instead of inventing a result.

Entry in the record	Meaning
“Roots visible at one opening”	Root evidence exists at that location.
“No roots visible on this side”	That view is negative; the whole root zone is not inspected.
“Not inspected to avoid disturbance”	An honest unknown, not a failure.
“Removed for justified assessment”	Record the reason and what was actually found.

Repeated tugging changes the setup. Keep the same observational viewpoints where practical.

MOISTURE LOG

Measure a change without inventing a dose

Inspection	Observed evidence	Action
A	Medium damp; pot still heavy; tray empty	No water added.
B	Accessible medium drying; pot lighter	Reassess the whole setup before adding water.
C	Tray holds runoff after watering	Remove retained runoff; note the cause.
D	Medium wet; leaves wilt after moving	Check exposure and root stage; do not infer thirst.

A scale measures mass, not a watering instruction

Fictional observations: the same pot weighs **620 g** after moistening and draining, then **580 g** at a later check.

620 – 580 = 40 g less total mass

That difference describes this observation. It is not an instruction to pour in 40 mL, proof that roots absorbed 40 mL, or a universal trigger. Repeat measurements only with the same pot, label, cover arrangement, and drainage state.

Always note	Useful wording
What changed?	“Cover removed since previous reading.”
What was inaccessible?	“Lower medium not examined without disturbance.”

HANDLING SEQUENCE

Prepare the receiving pot first

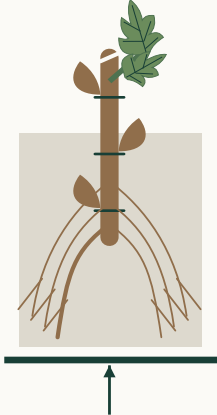
POT ON WITHOUT PULLING THE SHOOT

1 PREPARE



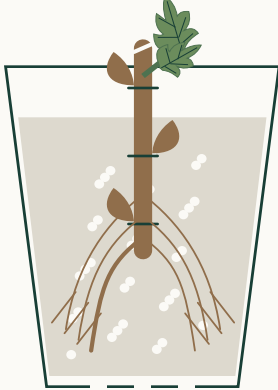
Have the receiving pot and a suitable opening ready.

2 SUPPORT



Support the plug and root system together.

3 SETTLE



Settle the medium; allow excess water to drain.

Before removal	During handling	After settling
Receiving pot and opening ready; label at hand.	Support the root plug and plant together. Do not pull the fresh shoot.	Check drainage and keep exposure suitable for adjustment.

Container size follows the current root system and method, not the ultimate size of a mature fig tree.

TRANSITION LADDER

Hardening is a sequence of observations

Current stage	Small next change	Observe before advancing
Rooted plant in protected setup	Increase ventilation or reduce cover gradually	Foliage response and actual medium condition.
Tolerating more ventilation	Move to the prepared, sheltered next position	Exposure changes, wind, stability and moisture.
Stable in the next position	Continue gradual adjustment	New growth and ability to maintain ordinary care.
Wilt follows a change	Return to less demanding exposure when needed	Reassess roots, medium and the size of the change.

Separate the variables

Ventilation, light, location, watering, and fertilizer are not one intervention. Write down the specific change before judging its effect.

Record	Your entry
Plant ID / root evidence	_____
Exposure before → after	_____
Response / next decision	_____

This ladder intentionally has no universal day count. The decision follows the plant’s response and the conditions available.

TROUBLESHOOTING ATLAS

A quiet bud and a soft base are different

DESCRIBE TISSUE BEFORE NAMING A CAUSE

FIRM / QUIET



Review stage and setup. Do not keep cutting it open just because it is quiet.

SHRIVELED



Check actual moisture and recent exposure. Appearance alone is incomplete.

SOFT / DARK



Inspect deterioration and drainage. Separate questionable material for assessment.

These are explanatory signs, not photographs or a pathogen-identification key.

Bring to a diagnostic review	Do not claim
Photo of the whole cutting and pot; dated close-up; moisture/drainage record.	A pathogen identity from color alone.
Sequence of recent changes, including ventilation, light and watering.	Proof that the last event caused every symptom.
Whether nearby cuttings share the pattern.	A universal cultivar failure from one tray.

CASE DESK • EVIDENCE

Case A: leaves arrive before proof of roots

The observation

CH-04 opens leaves in a protected pot. Its owner plans to transplant it because it looks greener than the other cuttings. No roots have been observed at the available viewing points.

Claim	Evidence available	Decision
"It has leaves, so it is rooted."	Only shoot growth is documented.	Not established. Record roots separately.
"No roots at the edge means none exist."	Only one viewpoint was checked.	Unresolved; do not repeatedly dismantle it.
"It needs fertilizer immediately."	Root stage remains uncertain.	Do not replace missing evidence with feeding.

The focused route

Keep the setup stable enough to observe. Check medium and drainage, preserve the label, and document root evidence when it becomes visible. Have the receiving pot ready without forcing a transplant today.

Next observation	What changes
Useful roots and continuing growth	Assess careful potting and gradual transition.
Softening base or spreading decline	Move to deterioration assessment, not automatic potting.

CASE DESK • ARITHMETIC

Case A: score the right milestone

From a batch of 12	Count at inspection	Fraction of original batch
Opened buds	9	$9 \div 12 = 75\%$
Roots observed	6	$6 \div 12 = 50\%$
Established after transition	5	$5 \div 12 = 41.7\%$

What these counts actually say

“75% opened buds” is supported by this fictional log. “75% became established plants” is not. Each milestone has its own definition and observation date.

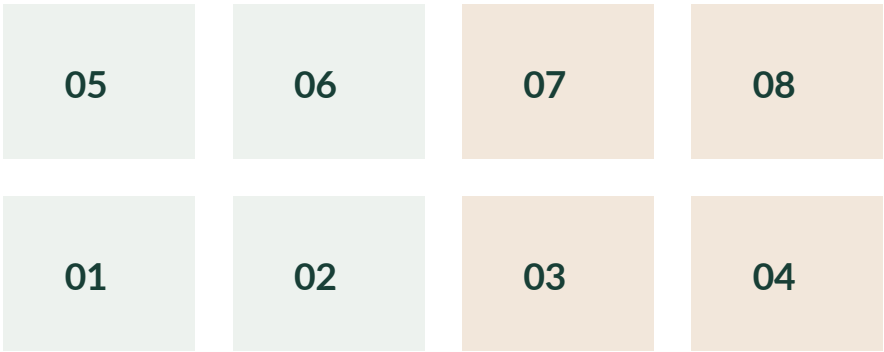
Milestone definition	Evidence to keep
Bud opening	Visible shoot development on a named cutting.
Roots observed	Root evidence and where it was seen.
Established	A stated transition milestone and subsequent condition.

Keep the original denominator. Removing failed cuttings from the tray does not remove them from the history of the batch.

Small batches support practical learning. They do not establish a commercial success rate or prove the superiority of a rooting product.

CASE DESK • POSITION MAP

Case B: one side of the tray wilts



WINDOW AT RIGHT

Affected: 03, 04, 07, 08

Compare with: 01, 02, 05, 06

In this fictional layout the two right-hand columns share the stronger exposure. Numbering the pots prevents “half the tray” from becoming an ambiguous record.

Check	Record
Exposure	Which IDs were reached by direct light or moving air?
Medium	Was wetness similar in the affected and unaffected pots?
Root stage	Were all cuttings actually at the same stage?
Timing	Did decline follow a specific move or ventilation change?

A spatial pattern identifies a comparison to make. It does not prove the cause on its own.

CASE DESK • NEXT DECISION

Case B: one correction, then a comparison

Finding	Focused action	Record next
Wet medium in both affected and unaffected pots; changed direct exposure	Correct the unsuitable exposure; keep drainage accessible.	Same-angle photos and whether fresh wilt spreads.
Only affected pots retain runoff	Correct that drainage difference.	Moisture behavior and condition of the bases.
Affected group has no documented roots	Reassess stage before advancing transition.	Root evidence without repeated disturbance.
No clear difference found	Keep the unknown explicit; seek closer assessment.	Whole setup, tissue details and chronological changes.

What would change your conclusion?

Write the observation that would cause you to take another route. For example: “If soft basal deterioration appears despite drainage correction, stop treating this as an exposure-only problem.”

Do not label a pesticide, fertilizer, or hormone as the solution when the organism or deficiency has not been identified.

PHYSICAL ALTERNATIVE

Layer an attached branch instead

ROOT FIRST, SEPARATE LATER

KEEP PARENT ATTACHMENT

TIP ABOVE SOIL

ROOTING ZONE

Separation point shown in rust: cut only after useful roots develop beyond it.

While attached	Before separation
Secure a suitable flexible branch with its tip above the rooting zone. Maintain appropriate moisture.	Confirm useful roots beyond the intended separation point; prepare aftercare before severing.

RHS describes spring or autumn layering for figs. This schematic shows locations, not a required wound depth or a guaranteed rooting interval.

FIRST-SEASON EXIT PLAN

Give each new plant a winter destination

State when cold approaches	Planning priority	Do not substitute
Leafy young fig	Suitable light and protection for active growth.	Dark dormant storage just because a date arrived.
Naturally leafless, dormant fig	A locally appropriate protected container plan and moisture checks.	Mature in-ground hardiness claims for a small exposed pot.
Freshly rooted late batch	Aftercare capacity before making more plants.	An assumption that all pots fit indoors later.
Unknown decline / unexpected leaf loss	Investigate the context.	Calling every leafless plant dormant.

Capacity worksheet

Rooting positions: ____
Receiving-pot positions: ____
Protected first-winter positions: ____

Use the smallest of these capacities to question the batch size. More cuttings are not automatically more usable plants.

Read the Chicago Hardy fig winter-care guide →

BATCH RECORD

One compact record that survives potting

ID	Stuck	Roots observed	Moved / response
CH-01	Date in notebook	At drainage opening	Ventilated; response recorded.
CH-02	Same batch	Not observed	Remain in current stage.
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Close the batch with a useful review

Question	Example improvement
Where did identity become uncertain?	Put individual labels in pots before cutting.
Which measurement mattered?	Note drainage state alongside pot mass.
Which stage was misreported?	Separate buds, roots and establishment.
What ran out first?	Reserve space for receiving pots and winter care.

Choose one practical improvement for the next batch. Keep the method and observations comparable before judging a new product or technique.

REFERENCE DESK

Source key and next resources

1. **Alabama Cooperative Extension** — Fig Production Guide
2. **Rutgers NJAES** — Figs in the Home Garden (FS1198)
3. **UF/IFAS** — The Fig (HS27/MG214)
4. **NC State Extension** — Extension Gardener Handbook: Propagation
5. **Royal Horticultural Society** — Hardwood cuttings
6. **University of Georgia Extension** — Propagating Deciduous Fruit Plants Common to Georgia (B818)
7. **Royal Horticultural Society** — How to grow figs
8. **University of Georgia Extension** — Home Garden Figs (C945)
9. **UF/IFAS** — Plant Propagation Techniques for the Florida Gardener (CIR579/MG108)
10. **N.C. Cooperative Extension, Gates County** — Propagating Figs Through Hardwood Cuttings
11. **Royal Horticultural Society** — Layering

Continue with the right next task

Chicago Hardy winter care • Container fit and repotting

Chicago Hardy Fig Tree • Fruit-tree collection

Cultivation claims are attributed by source number. Diagrams, bench layouts, example measurements, cases and records are original instructional tools. They are not observed trial results or guaranteed rooting performance.